

Okapia johnstoni

Okapi



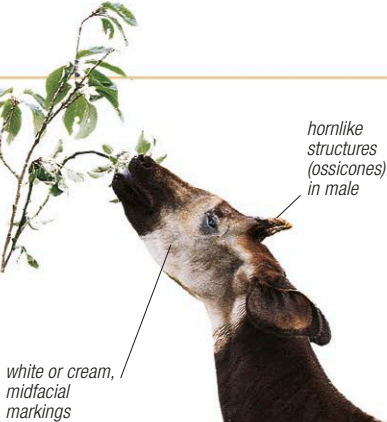
Location C. Africa

Length	6½–7¼ ft (2–2.2 m)
Tail	12–16½ in (30–42 cm)
Weight	440–770 lb (200–350 kg)
Social unit	Individual/Pair
Status	Endangered



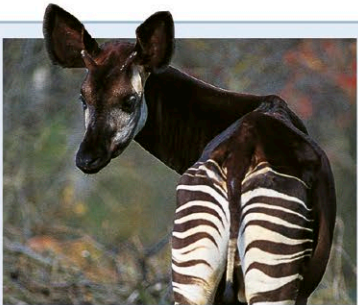
An elusive browser of thick tropical rain forest, the okapi feeds by day on leaves, soft twigs, shoots, fruit and other plant parts. It relies mainly on hearing in the dense forest and makes a “chuff” sound on meeting another okapi. Rival males “neck fight” like giraffes in the presence of a receptive female, and emit soft moaning sounds during courtship; the female indicates her readiness with similar calls and territorial scent marking. She is slightly taller than the male and 55–110 lb (25–50 kg) heavier. Both sexes look similar: long head and neck, dark muzzle and body (which slopes down from the shoulders), large, rear-set ears, and zebra-like stripes on the

rump and upper parts of the legs. The female bears a single calf in August–October, after a gestation of 425–491 days. She defends her offspring against predators, but the bond between mother and young is not as strong as in many hoofed mammals.

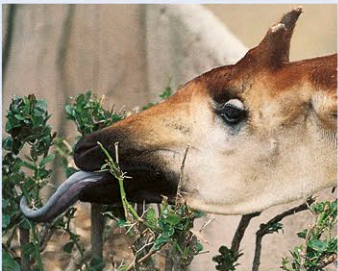


“FOREST ZEBRA”

The okapi was not identified as a distinct species until 1900–1901. Before that time it had been sighted occasionally, but mainly from the rear. Being shy and secretive, it had dashed away from humans into the dense forest. The impression of a forest-dwelling zebra was reinforced by the few specimens of old skin.



LONG TONGUE



The okapi curls its long, black, prehensile tongue around leaves, buds, and small branches, to draw them into the mouth. The tongue is also used for self grooming and, in the female, for cleaning her calf.

SLEEK COAT

The okapi's coat is short and sleek. The darker parts appear deep red, purple, maroon, brown, or black, according to the angle of the light.

Giraffa camelopardalis

Northern giraffe



Location Africa

Length	9¾–15 ft (3.8–4.7 m)
Tail	31–39 in (78–100 cm)
Weight	0.66–2 tons (0.6–1.9 tonnes)
Social unit	Variable
Status	Vulnerable



A native of dry savannas and open woodland, the northern giraffe browses higher than any other mammal, mainly for leaves of acacia and wild apricot, but also shoots, fruit, and other vegetation. The combination of greatly elongated tongue, skull, neck, shoulder region (pectoral girdle), and front legs provides the northern giraffe's great reach when browsing. Usually a small branch is drawn into the mouth with the long, flexible tongue; then the head is pulled

away to rake off leaves between the lobe-edged teeth. Among this species many distinctive features are large eyes and ears; a back that slopes steeply from shoulder to rump; stiltlike legs with large, heavy feet; and a thin tail with a long black tuft for

whisking away flies. The 2–4 specialized horns, called ossicones, are more developed in males than females. Feeding, drinking, and other activities occur in the morning and evening, occupying about 12 hours, with rest (standing up, as in most hoofed mammals) taking place at night, and cud-chewing in the hot midday. Cows mate with local dominant bulls, who have competed with each other by swaying and intercurling necks, and even clashing heads. This activity, “necking,” is more

a slow-motion ritual than a forceful encounter. It occurs mainly among young bulls, and when a new male arrives in the area. The winner reinforces success by sexually mounting his defeated rival. Cows, after a gestation period of 457 days, give birth to one calf (in rare cases 2), usually in the dry season. The newborn weighs up to 155 lb (70 kg) and stands 6½ ft (2 m) tall. For 10–30 days, the mother keeps it away from the herd; weaning takes place by 13 months. The giraffe's main predators are lions, leopards, and hyenas.

TALLEST ANIMAL

A mature female, such as this northern giraffe, measures 14¾ ft (4.5 m) to her horn tips; the male may be 3 ft (1 m) taller. This difference helps the sexes to avoid feeding competition as they utilize different levels. Despite having the longest neck of any animal, they have only 7 neck vertebrae, as in most other animals.

PATCHY DISTRIBUTION

Giraffes have long been divided into various subspecies based on coat pattern. However, recent genetic analysis has led to the recognition of 4 different species: the northern giraffe (shown on the main image), which includes the Nubian, Rothschild's, Kordofan, and West African subspecies; the reticulated giraffe (shown right and in the box); the southern giraffe, which comprises the Angolan and South African subspecies; and the Masai giraffe, which also includes the Thornicroft's subspecies.



DRINKING PROBLEM

The giraffe's great height means that, to drink water, it must splay its front legs, and even bend at the knees. When upright, its heart has to pump blood upward at enormous pressure to reach the brain, but when the head lowers to drink, a series of one-way valves regulate the blood's force and flow to prevent damage to the brain.

